

Extended Essay

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**To what extent does the film Barbie (2023) utilize ironic rhetoric to
critique and repackage consumer femininity in
American postfeminist culture?**

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1. Introduction

Greta Gerwig's *Barbie* (2023), produced by Mattel Films with Warner Bros. Pictures, spends much of its running time criticising the product that financed it. Through the human character Gloria, the film questions the demand that women be "so perfect" while never being allowed to say so (Gerwig, 2023); through Barbie Land's plastic perfection, it presents an ideal of femininity as a rehearsed daily routine; through Ken's subplot, it ridicules patriarchal authority. *Barbie* therefore presents a productive contradiction: a Mattel-affiliated film criticises ideals of femininity and consumption that have historically helped sustain the Barbie brand.

The cultural artefact analysed is the film itself. Gerwig's cinematic text, its dialogue, narrative structure and comic framing, supplies the primary evidence. The essay's argument develops through close analysis in three sequences: the presentation of Barbie Land, Gloria's monologue and Ken's "Kendom".

This essay asks: *to what extent does Greta Gerwig's Barbie (2023) utilize ironic rhetoric to critique and repackaging consumer femininity in American postfeminist culture?* "Consumer femininity" refers to the one defined through appearance, purchasable style and the display of empowerment, in which self-improvement is pursued through consumption. In this essay, "ironic rhetoric" is defined as the film's use of exaggeration, repetition, intertextual quotation and comic framing to make its own ideals visible as constructions. "American postfeminist culture" is used in the limited sense of the media sensibility Gill (2007) identifies in mainstream Anglo-American commercial culture: *Barbie* is a United States studio production, financed by an American toy corporation and built on a brand that has circulated in American consumer culture

since 1959. Barbie's self-awareness allows the critique of beauty standards, double binds and gender performance to be repackaged as brand appeal. This mechanism is called ironic complicity.

The method is rhetorical and textual analysis of the film, attending to language, repetition, setting, framing and narrative structure, supported by three frameworks: commodity feminism (Goldman, Heath & Smith, 1991), the postfeminist sensibility (Gill, 2007), and gender performativity (Butler, 1990). Since the approach is textual, it establishes the meanings the film constructs.



Figure 1: Barbie Movie Advertising Picture

2. Context and Theoretical Framework

2.1 Barbie, Femininity, and Consumer Culture

Mattel introduced the doll in 1959, conceived by the company's co-founder Ruth Handler (Kennedy, 2023), during what Nguyen (2023) calls the "Golden Age of Capitalism" (p. 3). The first doll embodied a contradiction the brand has never resolved: she was sold as an aspirational figure whose principal occupation was consumption. Nguyen (2023) describes this original identity as "untamed materialism", noting that Mattel priced the base doll cheaply at three dollars while profiting from the clothes and accessories sold alongside her (p. 3). Barbie could have been designed as an astronaut, but she was designed to be put together, sold, and accessorized. Eventually, being a woman means being able to buy something. This idea is what the film exaggerates in Barbie Land.

Since the beginning, Barbie doll has been designed with a representation of unrealistic body types and the lack of representation of multiple types of women. During the Women's Strike for Equality in 1970, protestors held signs that said, "I am not a Barbie doll," which placed Barbie and Mattel in the center of the feminist movement (Smithsonian Museum, 2023). Caldwell (2024) argues that Barbie's design aligned with and developed American hopes for women and mothers. Mattel chose to compete with these issues instead of removing themselves from these debates. The most evident example is the "We Girls Can Do Anything" campaign of 1985, and included Day-to-Night Barbie pictured in Figure 2. This Barbie was designed to come with an executive pink business suit to match her lyric, "We love working from 9 to 5" (Nguyen, 2023, pp. 9–10). Nguyen (2023) argues that this campaign was a direct rebuttal to the feminist

movement by Jenkins' argument that "any dream can come true" if women simply worked harder, but the campaign completely avoided addressing the structural inequalities.



Figure 2: Day-to-Night Barbie (left) Vs. Normal Barbie with Dress (right)

The mechanism is visible in the doll itself: professional life is signified entirely through costume, the same body being restyled from executive suit to evening dress, so that a career becomes an outfit that can be bought and exchanged. Empowerment is made available as a purchase rather than as a change in circumstance. This is an early instance of what Goldman, Heath and Smith (1991) call commodity feminism.

Nguyen's distinction between "Proto-Barbie" and "Socio-Barbie" is critical (2023, pp. 2–3) since an officially sanctioned Mattel production incorporates several of those external criticisms into its own narrative.

2.2 Theoretical Framework

Goldman, Heath and Smith (1991) explain how a critique can become a product. In the 1980s, second-wave feminism attacked advertising for demeaning and objectifying women. Advertisers didn't abandon their appeals to women, however; they borrowed language of feminism, highlighted feminist ideals like empowerment, independence and self-determination as their unique selling points and sold back to women as lifestyle choices expressible through purchase. The political content of those ideals was thereby evacuated, as feminism was "cooked to distill out a residue, an object: a look, a style" (Goldman et al., 1991, p. 336), and feminist social goals were converted into individual lifestyle choices. This framework is used below to explain how the film's feminist statements can be detached from their political demands and circulated as style.

Gill's (2007) account of the postfeminist sensibility explains why such an address is persuasive. Gill identifies an emphasis on individualism, choice and self-discipline; a shift of women as freely choosing subjects who monitor and present themselves; and a pervasive register of irony and knowingness. Irony, she argues, addresses "sign fatigue" by "hailing audiences as knowing and sophisticated consumers, flattering them with their awareness of intertextual references and the notion that they can 'see through' attempts to manipulate them", and it becomes "a way of 'having it both ways': expressing a sentiment while claiming not to have meant it (Gill, 2007, p. 159). This framework is used to explain the film's tone: its jokes position the viewer as too intelligent to be sold to, at the moment of selling.

Butler's (1990) theory of gender performativity supplies the third lens. Gender, in this account, is not an inner attribute that is subsequently expressed. It is, perhaps, "a stylised repetition of acts" through which the appearance of an essence is produced. This framework is used to analyse Barbie Land, where the daily rituals of grooming, greeting and display make the repetition on which gender depends unusually visible.

Taken together, the three frameworks support a working definition. Ironic complicity, as used in this essay, denotes a rhetorical strategy in which a commercial text voices the criticisms directed against it, invites recognition of its own artificiality, and converts that recognition into pleasure — so that seeing through the product becomes a way of enjoying it. Byrnes (2024) similarly reads the film's ambivalence as a postfeminist ideal rather than as a flaw in its politics. The sections that follow test how far the film's irony criticises consumer femininity, and how far it repackages it.

3. Barbie Land: Irony and Performed Consumer Femininity

Barbie Land is introduced as a world whose artificiality is impossible to overlook. Its surfaces are all pink and plastic. Its Dreamhouses have no exterior walls. Its showers run without water and its cups pour nothing (Gerwig, 2023). The world of the film does not expect the viewer to take this world as a serious, grounded environment. The manufactured world is shown in a way that makes the environment look like a diorama. The missing walls are the most obvious of these. Domestic space, conventionally associated with privacy and interiority, is converted into a surface for viewing, so that a Barbie's morning is staged for an audience assumed to be permanently present. As Figure 3 shows, the Dreamhouse is presented in section:

the dressing table stands in the open air, the mirror frame in front of it holds no glass, and the neighbouring house is equally exposed. Femininity in Barbie Land is consequently not something the characters possess but something they exhibit, and the showcase is designed to be looked at in the same way a boxed doll is looked at through cellophane.



Figure 3: Barbie Land's Open-Walled Dreamhouse

The exhibition is organised by repetition. Each day begins with an identical and pointless sequence: waking without dishevelment, floating instead of walking downstairs, and exchanging the same greetings “Hi Barbie!” or “Good morning, Barbie!” with the same neighbours (Gerwig, 2023). Using Butler's (1990) words: gender is not an expression of an inner self. Rather, gender is a characteristic that is constantly reproduced through a series of acts. In Barbie Land, this argument is made visually explicit. Barbies actually become a performance that is repeated.

Abdelwahed (2025) interprets the film similarly by arguing that femininity is a performance that is self-reflectively staged, and is not a given.

This performance is artificial and combines with an ironic argument. The film presents a world in which the attainment of feminine perfection happens with ease and is a continuous formation. The film is premised on the Fabian Society. The film places its audience in the pleasure of perfection, which is represented in a bright, ordered, and serene space, while recognizing this perfection is void of substance and consequence. This double position is a postfeminist knowingness, meaning the audience is able to enjoy the fantasy of perfection, and recognize it for what it is, constructed reality.

More critically, as things begin to unravel, the main character seeks to disrupt the performance. This disruption begins to break down the (presumably) choreographed opening number and cuts into the fantasy. This self-disruption causes her to interrupt the performance of perfection to ask, “Do you ever think about dying?”, her shower run cold, her toast burn, and her feet collapse due to permanent arches. The misfires are framed as a comedy of errors, but these disruptions are more ideological than logical, literally breaking the performance. This performance shows that the order centered around the appearance of the product fails to provide a life that is perpetually pleasure. Because the film has already established Barbie Land as a construction, the falling, arched feet register as evidence that the ideal of the system is to be maintained, not that it is a natural state.

This visibility has not been contained by the film exclusively. The release campaign carried Barbie’s pink aesthetic into the marketplace and beyond, with over 165 brand

partnerships. Mattel's Lisa McKnight stated the plan was for Barbie to be "everywhere" and "ubiquitous" and the film's obvious artificiality was turned into a brand visibility opportunity.

4. Gloria's Monologue

The speech that has circulated the most from the film and which Shepherd (2024) says is the most important for the feminist reading of the film is Gloria's monologue. It sets out the double bind of contemporary consumer femininity in a way that is direct and lacking in subtlety.

"You have to be thin, but not too thin. And you can never say you want to be thin. You have to say you want to be healthy, but also you have to be thin. You have to have money, but you can't ask for money because that's crass. You have to be a boss, but you can't be mean."

The monologue is constructed from second-person imperatives, such as "you have to", "you can't", which positions the listener within the system of obligation rather than examining it from a distance. In the second person the speech issues the very commands it condemns, thus the instruction reaches the listener before the argument does. The listener is positioned within the double bind, and the exhaustion described by the use of accumulating anaphora is experienced. As illustrated in Figure 4, the speech is presented as a case of direct address, showing Gloria looking at a Barbie Doll across the screen, meaning that the demands Gloria names are said to someone rather than to be pondered upon in solitude.



Figure 4: Gloria Monologue's Delivery Scene

This speech structure also helps to explain why this speech was so quotable. Every two lines of the speech can stand on their own. The film's best feminist statement is also its best condensed statement on the subject, and the two are the result of the same formal choice.

This, in and of itself, is a classic example of the kind of feminist cultural criticism Goldman, Heath and Smith (1991) discuss, which is susceptible to co-option. What Barbie adds to this example is that the co-option happened on social media (Shepherd, 2024), where the speech was frequently used in promotional posts. In this case, a feminist analysis of the gendered nature of consumerism provided the best means for a corporation which benefits from this consumerism the most to promote its products.

The film is aware of all this. Mattel's fictional CEO says to his board, "What do we really sell? We sell dreams, imagination, and sparkle. And when you think of sparkle, what do you think of after that? Female agency" (Gerwig, 2023). Stereotyping women and reducing agency to 'sparkle' is presented as satire; as Shepherd notes, "the irony is that Mattel actually does this by somehow managing to transform the Barbie brand into a feminist discourse with packaging that is much more about profit" (2024, pp. 83-84). The scene names the strategy the film itself employs, which is perhaps the best example of textual ironic complicity. It also shows the limit of the critique, which addresses patriarchy and beauty ideals, but doesn't cover the manufacturing, licensing, and the profit between them.

5. Ken and the Masculinity Subplot

Ken's storyline functions differently. It extends the film's satire to masculinity, and, at the same time, demonstrates most clearly what its comic method can and cannot achieve.

Ken, in his travels to the real world, doesn't learn much about patriarchy. What he does learn, through his travels, is to having outward signs of status and prestige, so he returns with horses, coats made of real fur and birds, an electric guitar and big trucks, and claiming his right to a room in the Dreamhouse, which he turns to the "Mojo Dojo Casa House" (Gerwig, 2023). This same logic permeates throughout the film and the Barbie Land joke. The film treats a masculine presence as a set of purchasable signs and a name that is an amalgamation of borrowed words. This exposes the fantasy that uses the name. In Kendom, patriarchy is decor.

Power is sustained by the Ken's comic performance and is not grounded in patriarchy or institutions. This authority is expressed through serenades, performance of possessions, and the song "I'm Just Ken". These together demonstrate masculine insecurities. The Barbies don't take control by destroying the framework of Kendom; they do, however, take advantage of Ken's need for female attention. This encourages Kens to perform to be watched and admired, therefore creating a competitive environment. For this reason, El-Mengad and Chakroune (2025) explain that the film's opinion on masculinity is more comic than analytical.

That comedy, however, defines the limit of the critique. Because patriarchal power is embodied inside a single insecure character and expressed through costume and interior decoration, it can be defeated by persuasion within a single sequence. While the comic framing may make it easier to ridicule patriarchy, it may also show that the structural system is a result of an incompetent individual's insecurity. The postfeminist sensibility is evident here; a structural critique is individualised, aestheticised and converted into character comedy, therefore entertaining rather than obligating the audience to engage with the critique. The irony becomes double edged; it not only makes the construction of gender visible across Barbie Land, but it also makes it harmless by undoing the system through flattery and not presenting it as a system.

6. Discussion and Evaluation

Integrating both analyses allows the research question to be answered along a spectrum rather than in a binary. Evidence for real critique is undeniable. Barbie Land makes femininity visible. Gloria's monologue captures a true structural double bind and accomplishes something

that is analytically accurate and emotionally resonant. Kendom is used to expose authority as purchasable signs.

There are equally strong structural limits to the critique. A film directed by Mattel Films cannot examine Mattel as a business. It depicts Mattel executives as ineffectual and comedy-inspiring men. As a result of this, there is a deflection of the question that the film itself wants to ask: what was the commercial decision that produced the worst iteration of Barbie, and who got rich from it? Shepherd (2024) comes to the same conclusion using a different technique, finding that the marketing around the film is postfeminist, while the film itself is feminist. This is the central paradox of the ironic complicity: the more a brand performs self-awareness, the better they defend themselves from the self-awareness that would create a demand for critique.

That said, the film is still positionally and structurally limited. It analyzes individual instances of patriarchy and beauty standards, and targets one insecure Ken as a comic foil. The film does not look into Mattel's business or how executives of the subsidiaries would fit in the framework of the film. What is poked fun at is the personality of Mattel rather than the structural business framework. La Porte and Cavusoglu (2023) call the film "bound by cognitive dissonance" and take the contradiction as a limitation to the work. The contradiction is one of the criteria. Compared to structural social change, the verdict holds: the film does not reshape the world it names and in this analysis nothing contradicts this verdict: no name is given to an institution and no economic structure is challenged. The methodology of the film's irony as a kind of rhetoric would treat the contradiction as a mechanism, because a text funded by a brand

can take a critical stance towards the brand's culture and not its economics. The two problems deal with different concerns and this answer takes the second.

The third level adds how the two are complementary. The film's self-aware critique creates a standpoint from which audiences can recognize criticism and still appreciate the Barbie brand. The film tells us that Barbie Land and Ken are ridiculous. Recognizing that Barbie Land is a false world, Ken is hilarious, and that the double bind is real places the audience as critical, as opposed to being complicit and acting in unthinking support of the brand. Audiences still can appreciate the brand. Self-conscious commodity feminism, as found in the arguments of Goldman et al. (1991), seeks not to subvert commodity capitalism but to intensify feminism through critically borrowed language.

There are several limitations that qualify the findings. This essay's analysis is textual and rhetorical. This means this essay can reveal the meanings a campaign is conveying, but this method cannot reveal how an audience is actually receiving those meanings. This essay is also limited to the American market. Because of this, it is not possible to generalize the conclusions about American consumer identity towards the campaign's international operations. Based on El-Mengad and Chakroune's (2025), the reception of the 2023 Barbie campaign is likely much different in other countries. Because *Barbie* (2023) is recent, the body of peer-reviewed scholarship remains thin, and several of my sources are undergraduate or master's theses (Nguyen, 2023; Caldwell, 2024; Shepherd, 2024) whose evidential weight is lower than that of the peer-reviewed work of Goldman, Heath and Smith (1991) and Gill (2007) on which the theoretical framework rests.

7. Conclusion

Barbie (2023) stages ironic forms of consumer femininity in a substantial and bound way. Barbie Land illustrates femininity as a stylized performance that is sustained through repetition and display. In Gloria's monologue, we see the contradiction of this performance and in Kendom we see the patriarchal system as the accumulation of purchasable signs.

The same irony also allows the critique to be restated. Barbie is more critical and explicit in its assessment of problematic beauty standards, gendered double binds, and harmful portrayals of masculinity than in its assessment of the systems of corporate capitalism that exploit and benefit from these problematic standards and portrayals. It enables the viewer to have a critical distance from the doll and an attachment to the brand at the same time. Barbie's ironic stance is most effective in creating a position that is pleasurable in its recognition of the contradiction of feminist critique and consumption.

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